

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN VENEZUELA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. Introduction & Framework
2. How the System Works
3. Quick Reference: Success Rates
4. Step 1: Target Identification
5. Step 2: Documentation
6. What to Gather, and Where to Find It
7. Step 3: Building Local Opposition
8. Step 4: Legal Challenges
9. Turning Your Evidence Into Arguments
10. Step 5: Media Strategy
11. Emails & Letters
12. If You Have Little Time or Few Resources: The Rapid-Fire Version
13. When the System Is Tilted
14. When It's Actual Corruption — And Who Is Captured
15. Integration & Timeline
16. Final Assessment

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Why This Matters

Across Venezuela, and above all south of the Orinoco, communities discover that the forest they live in, the river they drink from, the land their people have held for generations has been opened to mining — by decree, by an armed group, or by both at once. A gold or coltan pit. A dredge tearing up a riverbed. A militarised "mining zone." An airstrip and a camp where a forest used to be. The first sign is often the mercury in the fish, the malaria, the outsiders with weapons, or the discovery that your territory sits inside a "strategic development zone" no one ever asked you about.

This guide is a practical manual for those communities. It explains how the approval system for large projects is supposed to work in Venezuela, why so little of it functions today, where the genuine — if narrow and mostly international — openings are, what documentation actually matters, how to organise as safely as possible, and how to use the levers that have, at great cost, achieved something here. It does not promise victory. It promises a clear-eyed method that gives you the best possible chance while keeping you and your community as safe as circumstances allow — and in Venezuela, safety is not a footnote. It is the first consideration on every page, because much of the harm is enforced by armed men.

You must hear the hardest truths before anything else. First, **Venezuela's institutions have collapsed as protectors of the environment and of rights.** The courts are not independent. The environmental and mining ministries promote extraction, not restraint. Domestic legal remedies, on paper real, in practice rarely function against a project the state and its allied armed groups want. Second, **much of the destruction is driven not by an ordinary company but by armed actors** — Venezuelan gangs (*sindicatos*), Colombian guerrilla groups, and their entanglement with parts of the military — operating in a landscape the reporting describes as lawlessness. Confronting them directly is not opposition; it is mortal danger. Third, **the danger to those who document and speak is severe:** journalists and observers have been detained, communities threatened and displaced. This guide is built around those realities.

And yet there are truths on the other side, and they are real. The Orinoco Mining Arc was created **without the environmental-impact study the Constitution requires (Article 129) and without the free, prior, and informed consultation of Indigenous peoples it requires (Article 120)** — and the National Assembly formally rejected it. By Venezuela's own supreme law, the project is illegal. That illegality, unenforceable at home, is a powerful instrument abroad. International documentation campaigns have put the Arco Minero before the world; the Inter-American Commission and United Nations bodies have taken up the lack of consultation and the human and environmental toll; Indigenous peoples have organised in defence of their territories; and the global concern for the Amazon has begun, slowly, to reach a crisis long ignored. These show that even here there is a narrow, mostly international space in which

documentation and organisation can matter.

The projects that devastate communities in Venezuela follow gold, coltan, diamonds, and iron, overwhelmingly in the Amazon and Orinoco south — on the lands of the Pemón, Ye'kwana, Sanemá, Warao, Kariña, Mapoyo, Hoti, Eñepá, Yanomami, and many other peoples. What they share is that those who profit are far away and armed, and those who bear the harm — mercury, malaria, violence, the loss of a sacred river — were never asked.

The Strategic Framework

The core of this guide is a simple idea: **a destructive project is not a single event but a chain of decisions and dependencies, and a chain can be pressured at its weakest link.** In Venezuela the chain runs partly outside the law, so your job is to find the link you can safely reach — and, most often, that link is not domestic but international.

Every large project still depends on things it needs: a claim to legality it cannot honestly make; the acquiescence or ignorance of the outside world; buyers and financiers for its gold; the absence of scrutiny. Each of these is a potential point of leverage. The project's illegality under Venezuela's own Constitution and the anti-mining law passed by the National Assembly is a documented fact usable before international bodies and markets. The gold's route to world markets is a pressure point through sanctions, due-diligence, and buyer scrutiny. The invisibility the destruction has relied on can be ended by documentation and the global Amazon spotlight. Your task is to find which of these narrow links your community can reach without exposing its people to the armed actors on the ground.

Critical Caveat: Which Situation Are You In?

Throughout this guide you will find honest assessments, because a guide that promised you could stop an armed, state-backed mining operation by filing the right objection would be lying — and in Venezuela that lie could get people killed. Here is the honest frame.

Where the harm is driven by a formal, visible actor — a state enterprise, a decree, a named project — and can be opposed through documentation and international, Indigenous, and church channels, there is a narrow but real space to raise its cost and constrain it. Venezuela's actual advances came from exactly this: rigorous documentation, Indigenous organisation, and sustained international and inter-American pressure that made a hidden crime visible and costly.

Where the harm is driven by armed groups on the ground — *sindicatos*, guerrillas, militarised camps — direct opposition is not a strategy; it is lethal, and protection and evacuation may matter more than any campaign. For these situations, the realistic and safer aims are documentation from a safe distance, protection of people, and feeding the record to the international and Indigenous-rights bodies that can act where you cannot.

Knowing which situation you are in — and, above all, what armed danger it carries — is the most important judgment you will make. Much of this guide is designed to help you judge accurately and act only in ways that do not put your people in front of guns.

How to use this guide

Read the whole thing once before doing anything, and read the organising and tilted-system sections with particular care, because in Venezuela safety and the international dimension govern everything. Two principles run through every page. First, **safety before all**: never confront armed actors, never let a person stand alone or exposed, and treat the protection of your people as the first goal. Second, **the leverage is mostly international**: because domestic institutions do not function as protectors, your strongest moves join rigorous documentation and Indigenous organisation to the international, inter-American, United Nations, church, and market channels that can still reach a crime the Venezuelan state will not stop.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pressure a chain you cannot see. This section maps what the system is supposed to be, what it has actually become, the rules that still matter (mostly as instruments abroad), the incentives that drive the destruction, and the overseers — overwhelmingly international — who can still act.

The Bodies That (Nominally) Decide — And What Has Become of Them

The environmental ministry (MINEC) and the "ecological mining" ministry. On paper the Ministry of Ecosocialism

sets environmental policy and the mining ministry regulates extraction. In practice these bodies promote and administer the very mining that is devastating the south, and the environmental-licensing function that should restrain projects has been subordinated to the drive for gold and minerals. Do not expect them to act as protectors; treat their documents as evidence of what was authorised, and of what was not.

The military and the "strategic development zone." The Orinoco Mining Arc is a militarised zone, and the armed forces are deeply entangled in its administration and, by many accounts, in the mining economy itself. This is the decisive fact of the Venezuelan system: the body that should enforce the law is a party to the activity. It is also why direct confrontation on the ground is so dangerous.

Armed non-state actors. Much of the actual mining is run by *sindicatos* (armed gangs) and Colombian guerrilla groups, under military protection or complicity. They are not a body you petition or challenge; they are a danger you document from a distance and avoid.

The courts and the public prosecutor. Formally independent, in practice widely regarded as controlled and unwilling to act against state-backed extraction. Domestic litigation is, realistically, a way to build a record and exhaust remedies for the international stage, not a reliable route to a remedy at home.

The National Assembly — and its contested legitimacy. In 2018 an opposition-held National Assembly passed a law declaring all mining in the Arco Minero and in protected areas illegal — a powerful legal and political instrument. But the government does not recognise or enforce it. Its value, like the Constitution's, is as an authoritative statement of illegality usable before the world.

Indigenous peoples and their own authorities. The Constitution recognises Indigenous peoples, their territories, and their governance, and their own councils and organisations are, in the affected south, among the few legitimate and functioning decision-making bodies. Their consent — never sought — is both a legal necessity under the Constitution and ILO Convention 169 and a moral and organisational foundation.

How a Decision Is Actually Made — The Journey of a Project

In a functioning system a project would be sited, assessed, consulted, licensed, and built. In Venezuela's south the sequence has been inverted and hollowed out.

Stage 1 — The decree. The Arco Minero was created by presidential decree in 2016, opening ~112,000 square kilometres — about an eighth of the country — to mining, including in protected areas and Indigenous habitats.

Stage 2 — The requirements that were skipped. The Constitution required an environmental and sociocultural impact study (Article 129) and free, prior, and informed consultation of the affected Indigenous peoples (Article 120). Neither was done. The National Assembly rejected the plan. These omissions are not loopholes; they are the core of the project's illegality.

Stage 3 — Militarisation and armed control. The zone was militarised, and mining on the ground fell to *sindicatos*, guerrillas, and military-linked networks, in a setting the reporting calls lawless.

Stage 4 — Extraction and its route to market. Gold and minerals are mined and then move, through informal and formal channels, toward buyers and world markets — the stage at which international sanctions, due-diligence rules, and buyer scrutiny become pressure points.

Stage 5 — The harm. Deforestation, mercury contamination of rivers and people, malaria, violence, displacement, and the tearing of Indigenous life — the toll that documentation must capture and carry outward.

The Rulebook — The Provisions That Still Matter (Mostly Abroad)

You do not need to be a lawyer, but you must know the handful of instruments that give your case its force — chiefly before international bodies and markets:

- **The Constitution of 1999** — Article 129 (mandatory environmental and sociocultural impact studies), Article 120 (free, prior, informed consultation of Indigenous peoples for resource use in their habitats), Article 127 (environmental rights), and the recognition of Indigenous peoples and territories.
- **ILO Convention 169**, ratified by Venezuela — the binding requirement of free, prior, and informed consultation, and the standard the inter-American and UN bodies apply.
- **The Organic Law of the Environment and the Environmental Penal Law** — the framework and the criminalisation of environmental damage, usable to document that what is happening is a crime under Venezuela's own law.

- **The National Assembly's 2018 law on the southern megareserve** — its declaration that all mining in the Arco Minero and protected areas is illegal, an authoritative instrument for the international stage.
- **The inter-American and UN human-rights instruments** — the American Declaration and the mandate of the Inter-American Commission (which still monitors Venezuela), and the UN human-rights bodies and Fact-Finding Mission.

The pattern to hold in mind: at home these rules are largely unenforced, but each is a documented, authoritative statement that the project violates Venezuela's own supreme law and its international obligations — and that is exactly the instrument the international, inter-American, and market channels can act on.

Follow the Money — Why the Destruction Continues

Understand the incentives and you understand why it continues. A collapsed economy under sanctions turned to gold and minerals as a lifeline, and the south's forests became a source of hard currency for the state and for the armed networks entangled with it. Officials and armed actors profit directly; the environmental and Indigenous cost falls on people far from power and far from the buyers of the gold. There is no neutral referee to persuade; the referee is a beneficiary. Your leverage therefore does not come from convincing a domestic decision-maker. It comes from raising the cost elsewhere — making the crime visible and undeniable, engaging the international and inter-American bodies, and reaching the markets and buyers through whom the gold must eventually pass.

The Overseers — Who Can Still Act

In Venezuela the meaningful overseers are almost entirely outside the state:

- **The Inter-American Commission on Human Rights (IACHR).** Venezuela withdrew from the Inter-American Court's contentious jurisdiction, but as an OAS member it remains under the Commission's monitoring, and the Commission receives petitions, requests for precautionary measures, and information, and has addressed the Arco Minero and the lack of consultation.
- **The United Nations human-rights system.** The OHCHR presence and the UN Fact-Finding Mission on Venezuela have documented the absence of consultation and the violation of rights, bringing international scrutiny the government cannot fully deflect.
- **International documentation and solidarity organisations.** Groups that combine satellite monitoring, field testimony, and international advocacy — the model that made the Arco Minero visible to the world — are the most active and effective channel available.
- **Indigenous peoples' organisations and the Catholic Church.** Among the few legitimate, functioning, and relatively protected voices inside the affected regions, and essential partners and witnesses.
- **Markets and sanctioning states.** The due-diligence and sanctions regimes governing Venezuelan gold are a pressure point on the destruction's economic lifeline.

These are the overseers your strategy must be built to reach. Much of the rest of this guide is about producing documentation strong enough to move them — safely, and from a distance the armed actors cannot close.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit, calibrate honestly — and weigh the danger, which in Venezuela's mining south can be lethal. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns from how Venezuelan and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are not in the table: **whether the harm is driven by a formal actor you can name and document or by armed groups you must avoid, and whether you can reach the international channels that are the real levers here.** In every category, the safety of your people comes before any outcome.

Individual Step Success Rates

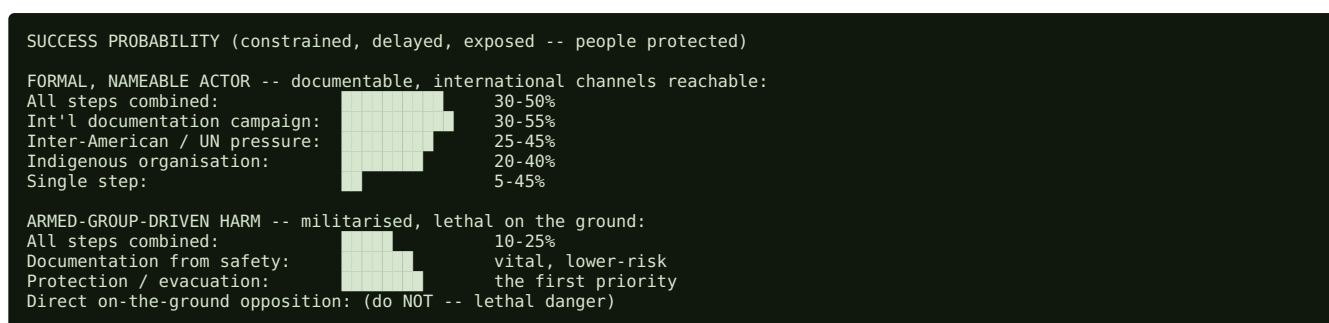
Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only (incl. satellite/remote)	5-15%	1-6 months	low-moderate	The foundation and shield for every other step
Domestic legal challenge (record-building)	5-15%	12-48 months	low-moderate	Remedies exhausted; record for the international stage
Indigenous organisation & territorial defence	20-40%	ongoing	low-moderate	Territory asserted; consent withheld; a legal and moral anchor
Church & humanitarian channels	15-25%	ongoing	low	Protection, witness, and a route for testimony

Church & humanitarian channels	15-55%	Ongoing	low	Protection, witness, and a route for testimony
Inter-American (IACHR) petition / precautionary measures	25-45%	6-36 months	low	Scrutiny; protection; an authoritative finding
UN human-rights engagement (OHCHR / mechanisms)	25-45%	6-36 months	low	International documentation and pressure
International documentation & solidarity campaign	30-55%	6-36 months	low-moderate	Visibility; cost; the crime made undeniable
Market / sanctions / gold due-diligence pressure	20-45%	6-36 months	low	The economic lifeline scrutinised and constrained
All steps combined (formal actor, reachable)	30-50%	12-48 months	low-moderate	Constrained, delayed, exposed; people protected
All steps combined (armed-group-driven harm)	10-25%	12-48 months	low-moderate	Documented, exposed; protection the first win

Key insight: all steps together beat any single one, and Venezuela's real strengths are unusual: the project's **illegality under the country's own Constitution and the National Assembly's law**, the **binding but violated Indigenous consultation right**, the still-active **Inter-American Commission and UN monitoring**, the proven **international documentation model**, and the **market/sanctions pressure on Venezuelan gold**. Its constraints are severe: **collapsed and captured domestic institutions, militarisation and armed-group control, lethal danger to defenders and journalists**, and a **severed Inter-American Court jurisdiction**. The through-line is that the leverage is overwhelmingly international.

A note on cost: documenting (especially safely and remotely), organising, and reaching the international bodies are inexpensive relative to their impact. The expenditure that changes outcomes is secure documentation and communication, and partnership with an international documentation or human-rights organisation that can carry the record to the IACHR, the UN, and the markets.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The arguments that move outcomes in Venezuela are **legal-and-evidentiary, carried abroad** — the project's violation of the Constitution's impact-study and consultation requirements, the National Assembly's declaration of illegality, the documented environmental and Indigenous harm, and the gold's route to market. What does not work — and is lethally dangerous — is confronting armed groups or the military on the ground, or expecting a captured domestic court to deliver a remedy. Keep the fight documentary, Indigenous-anchored, and international, and success becomes measurable in **visibility, protection, authoritative findings, and market and diplomatic cost**.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Documentation, safely gathered** — the foundation of every international, inter-American, and market channel, and, gathered from a distance, the lowest-risk step.
2. **International documentation and solidarity** — the model that made the Arco Minero visible and the most effective lever available.
3. **Inter-American and UN engagement** — the authoritative scrutiny and protection the domestic system will not provide.
4. **Indigenous organisation and the church** — the legitimate, functioning, relatively protected voices inside the affected regions.
5. **Market, sanctions, and due-diligence pressure** — reaching the destruction's economic lifeline.

What Venezuelan Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **The crime's illegality is its greatest vulnerability** — created without the constitutionally-required impact study or Indigenous consultation, and rejected by the National Assembly, the Arco Minero is unlawful under Venezuela's own supreme law, and that documented illegality is a powerful instrument before the IACHR, the UN, and the markets even though it is unenforced at home. **Documentation is what changed the picture** — satellite monitoring, field testimony, and international advocacy, led by organisations such as those built for exactly this, turned a hidden devastation into a documented global environmental crime. **The Inter-American Commission and the UN still reach** where the courts do not, taking up the absence of consultation and the toll on Indigenous peoples. **Indigenous organisation and the church** are the enduring anchors on the ground. **And the danger is defining** — journalists and observers have been detained and communities threatened, so every method here is shaped first by safety. The through-line: **document safely, anchor in Indigenous rights and the Constitution's own words, and carry the case to the international bodies and markets that can act where Venezuela's institutions will not.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Before you gather a neighbour or write a word, you must know exactly what you are facing, who drives it, where it can be safely reached, and — in Venezuela above all — what armed danger it carries. Acting before you know these things wastes effort and can be fatal. Spend your first days answering five questions, quietly and with trusted people.

The Five Questions

1. What exactly is the harm, and who drives it — a formal actor or armed groups? Is it a decreed zone, a state or mixed enterprise, a named concession — something formal you can document and name? Or is it a *sindicato*, a guerrilla group, a militarised camp — an armed actor you must document from a distance and never confront? This distinction shapes everything, above all your safety.

2. Whose territory, and which peoples, does it affect? Does it fall on the lands of the Pemón, Ye'kwana, Sanemá, Warao, or another Indigenous people? If so, the Constitution's and ILO 169's consultation and consent requirements are engaged — never met — and Indigenous authorities are both the legitimate decision-makers and your foundation. Identify the peoples, their territories, and their organisations.

3. What makes it illegal under Venezuela's own law? Was there an environmental and sociocultural impact study (Article 129)? A free, prior, informed consultation (Article 120)? Does it sit in a protected area or the southern megareserve the National Assembly declared off-limits? Each missing requirement is documented illegality — your strongest instrument abroad.

4. Which international, inter-American, or market channel can you reach? Can the case be carried to the IACHR or the UN? Is there an international documentation or human-rights organisation you can safely partner with? Does the gold or mineral move toward buyers or markets subject to due-diligence or sanctions? Because domestic remedies barely function, the reachable external channel is usually the real target.

5. How exposed are your people — and what protection is possible? This is a safety assessment, and in Venezuela's mining south it can decide life and death. Are defenders already threatened? Is the area militarised or gang-controlled? What protection — distance, the church, Indigenous organisation, international visibility, relocation — is possible, and how soon? Judge this honestly, first, and let it govern every later step.

Reading the Answers

Work the five questions together and a picture forms. **A formal, nameable actor on Indigenous land without consultation** points toward documentation plus the Indigenous-rights and inter-American channels and the constitutional-illegality argument. **Armed-group-driven harm in a militarised zone** points toward safe, remote documentation, protection, and feeding the record to international bodies — never confrontation. **A gold stream reaching world markets** points toward the due-diligence and sanctions channel. **In every case**, the reachable lever is almost always international, and safety comes first.

Naming Your Realistic Goal

Before you go further, decide with a small, trusted group what winning would actually mean — concretely, honestly, and safely. Depending on your situation, a realistic goal might be: protecting your people and territory; documenting the harm and its illegality for the international record; winning an authoritative finding or precautionary measures from the IACHR or the UN; securing international visibility that raises the crime's cost; constraining the gold's route to market; or sustaining

Indigenous territorial defence and withheld consent. Outright stopping an armed, state-backed operation from within Venezuela is, for most communities, not a realistic near-term goal, and pursuing it through confrontation is lethal. A goal that fits your situation — documentary, Indigenous-anchored, international, and above all protective of your people — is not a lesser aim here; it is the responsible one, and it is the path by which Venezuela's crisis has been made visible and costly to those who profit from it.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Documentation is the foundation of everything that follows, and in Venezuela it is also the single most powerful and — done carefully — the safest thing a community can do. Because the domestic system will not act, and because much of the harm is enforced by armed men, the campaign is won or lost on whether the crime can be made visible, undeniable, and legally framed for the international bodies and markets that can act. A community — or an ally documenting on its behalf — that can show, in dated, sourced, organised form, exactly what is happening, on whose land, and in violation of which of Venezuela's own laws holds the one instrument that has actually moved this crisis. A community with only anger, or that exposes its people to gather it, has far less, and far more risk.

The Mindset: Build a Record for the World — Safely

Approach documentation as if you are assembling a file that an Inter-American Commission lawyer, a UN investigator, an international journalist, and a gold-market compliance officer will read — people who can act on concrete, provable facts and framed illegality. Everything must be dated, attributed to a source, and stored securely in more than one place, including with trusted allies outside the region and, ideally, outside the country. And it must be gathered without putting people in front of guns: in Venezuela's mining south, safe distance, remote methods, and secure handling are not refinements but the difference between a living witness and a dead one.

What to Document

The harm itself. Deforestation, the pits and dredges, the poisoned rivers, the mercury in fish and people, the malaria, the displacement — captured wherever possible from a safe distance, with dates and locations. Satellite and remote imagery, the method that made the Arco Minero visible to the world, lets you document devastation without entering danger, and should be a first resort.

The illegality. The absence of the constitutionally-required environmental and sociocultural impact study (Article 129); the absence of the free, prior, and informed consultation of the affected Indigenous peoples (Article 120); the location within a protected area or the southern megareserve; the National Assembly's declaration of illegality. Assemble the official decrees and the legal instruments alongside the proof that the requirements were skipped — the gap between them is your case.

Whose land, and whose consent was never sought. Document the Indigenous peoples and territories affected, their customary use and governance, and the fact that their consent was never obtained. This is both the legal heart of the case under the Constitution and ILO 169 and its moral centre.

The actors — carefully, and from a distance. To the extent it can be done safely, document who drives the harm: a state or mixed enterprise, a decree, or — where armed groups are involved — the pattern of their presence and control, gathered remotely and never by approaching them. Where the military or officials are implicated, record the documented, verifiable facts only.

The route to market. Where you can, document how the gold or mineral moves — the buyers, routes, and enterprises — because that is the pressure point for the due-diligence and sanctions channels.

The threats and attacks. Document, with dates and sources and with utmost care for safety, the threats, detentions, violence, and displacement connected to the mining — the record that supports protection requests and international accountability.

How to Document Safely and Credibly

Safety governs documentation in Venezuela more than almost anywhere in this guide. Prefer remote and satellite methods over field exposure; never approach armed actors or militarised sites; protect the identities of witnesses; and assume devices and communications may be compromised, using secure storage and channels and keeping backups with allies abroad. Record dates and sources for everything; prefer imagery, official documents, and verifiable testimony over rumour; and be accurate and restrained, because a file that overstates can be dismissed and can endanger. Above all,

partner early with an experienced international documentation or human-rights organisation: they bring the satellite capacity, the secure methods, the legal framing, and the channels to the IACHR, the UN, and the markets — and they can carry the record outward so your community does not have to stand exposed to do so.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This section turns documentation into a concrete list of sources. In Venezuela, the official record is thin and hostile, so the richest sources are remote imagery, Indigenous testimony, and the work of the international organisations already documenting this crisis — and the legal instruments that establish illegality. Work through these carefully, and safely.

Remote and Physical Evidence

Satellite and remote imagery. This is the first and safest resort. Freely and commercially available satellite imagery, and the analyses published by forest- and mining-monitoring initiatives, document deforestation, the spread of pits and dredges, and river damage across the Arco Minero without anyone entering danger. Establish a dated visual record of what the mining has done and is doing.

Water, mercury, and health evidence. Where it can be gathered safely, evidence of mercury contamination in rivers, fish, and people, and of malaria and other health harms, is among the most powerful proof of the toll. Independent scientific and medical assessment, and the findings of researchers and health workers, give this authority; gather it without exposing people to the mining sites themselves.

Territorial and land evidence. Maps and documentation of Indigenous territories, protected areas, and the megareserve boundaries establish whose land the mining occupies and which protected zones it violates.

The Legal and Official Record

The decrees and the Constitution. The 2016 decree creating the Arco Minero, the constitutional provisions it violated (Articles 129 and 120), the environmental and Indigenous-rights laws, and the National Assembly's 2018 law declaring southern mining illegal are all documentable instruments. Assemble them to show, in Venezuela's own words, that the project is unlawful.

Whatever official mining and environmental documents can be obtained. Concession and enterprise records, ministry statements, and any environmental documentation — often revealing precisely by their absence or inadequacy. Treat these as evidence of what was and was not done.

Testimony and Human Evidence

Indigenous and community testimony. The accounts of the affected peoples — of the harm, the lack of consultation, the violence, the loss — are central evidence and the moral core of the case. Gather them with consent, with care for the safety and identity of those who speak, and through trusted Indigenous organisations and the church.

The record of threats and attacks. The detentions, threats, and violence against those who document or resist — the basis for protection requests and international accountability.

The Organisations and Channels That Carry the Case

For a Venezuelan community these are not a last resort but the central resource:

- **International documentation and human-rights organisations.** The groups that combine satellite monitoring, field networks, legal framing, and international advocacy — the model that made the Arco Minero visible — are the most important partners you can find, and can carry your record to the world.
- **Indigenous peoples' organisations.** The councils and federations of the affected peoples, the legitimate authorities and the front-line witnesses.
- **The Catholic Church and humanitarian networks.** Among the few functioning, relatively protected channels for testimony, protection, and witness inside the affected regions.
- **The Inter-American Commission and UN bodies.** The recipients of petitions, precautionary-measure requests, and information, and the sources of authoritative findings.

Turning Sources into a Case

As you gather, sort everything against the chain from Section 2 — the decree, the skipped requirements, the militarisation, the route to market, the harm — so each piece attaches to the point it proves, and keep a separate, secure file of threats and attacks. By the end you should be able to show, with dated and sourced evidence, what is happening, on whose land, in violation of which of Venezuela's own laws, and at what human and environmental cost — the record that the international, inter-American, and market channels can act on where Venezuela's own institutions will not.

Canaima, the Tepuis, and the Rivers

Some of what is at stake is globally recognised, and documenting the specific protected places a project threatens gives your case unusual weight. **Canaima National Park** — a UNESCO World Heritage site of ancient tepuis and waterfalls, and Pemón territory — sits within the mining-pressured south, and encroachment on and around it is powerful evidence of what is being lost. The **Caroní** river basin, whose waters feed the country's main hydroelectric system, and the **Cuyuní** and **Orinoco** and their tributaries, are being loaded with sediment and mercury by gold mining, a harm that reaches far beyond the mine and even threatens the nation's own water and power. Document, with maps and dated imagery, where mining sits in relation to these named protected areas, World Heritage sites, and river basins: a project that degrades a World Heritage tepui landscape or poisons a river that a nation depends on is a story and a legal fact of a different order, and one the international bodies and the world's press respond to.

Mercury: The Evidence That Travels

Mercury deserves particular attention, because it is both a grave harm and a legally potent fact. Its use in gold mining is prohibited under Venezuelan law and restricted under the international Minamata Convention, yet it is used across the Arco Minero, contaminating rivers, fish, and people — with documented elevated levels among downstream and Indigenous communities. Where it can be gathered safely and with proper scientific and medical support, evidence of mercury contamination is among the most compelling proof available: it is measurable, it is attributable, it violates domestic and international law, and it harms human health directly. Pair any such evidence with the testimony of health workers and the affected communities, gathered with care for consent and safety.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documentation gives you a case; organisation gives it weight and gives your people protection. But in Venezuela's mining south, organising carries mortal danger, and how you build opposition can determine whether your community survives as much as whether it succeeds. This section is about building resistance that is collective, Indigenous-anchored, internationally connected, and — above all — as safe as it can possibly be made.

The Overriding Rule: Never Confront the Guns

The single most important rule in Venezuela is that you do not confront armed actors — not the *sindicatos*, not the guerrillas, not the militarised mining apparatus. This is not opposition; it is a way to get people killed. The Venezuelan model of resistance that has achieved something works precisely by NOT meeting force with force: it documents from a safe distance, organises legitimately and often quietly, anchors in Indigenous authority and the church, and carries the fight outward to the international arena where the armed actors cannot reach. Build everything around that rule.

Start With a Small, Trusted Core — and a Security Plan First

Begin with a small, trusted core, and in Venezuela make security the very first element of organising, not an afterthought. With experienced allies — Indigenous organisations, the church, an international human-rights partner — develop a security and communication plan before you do anything else: how you communicate securely, how you protect the most exposed, what you do if threatened, and when relocation or evacuation is the right and honourable choice. Assume surveillance and infiltration. A campaign that does not organise its safety first is not ready to act.

Widen Through Legitimate, Protected Structures

Indigenous authority first. Where the affected people are Indigenous — as they overwhelmingly are in the mining south — the community's own councils and organisations are the legitimate decision-makers, the front-line witnesses, and the anchor of both the legal case and the resistance. Work through them; centre their consent, their governance, and their leadership.

The Catholic Church and humanitarian networks. Among the few functioning, relatively protected institutions in the

affected regions, the church can offer witness, protection, a route for testimony, and a moral voice that carries internationally. It has been an important presence in Venezuela's crisis.

International partners early. Because the leverage is international and the danger local, connect early — carefully and securely — with international documentation and human-rights organisations and, through them, the inter-American and UN bodies. This is not a step for after a tragedy; it is the core of the strategy and a source of protection.

Choose Only Tactics That Do Not Expose Your People

Venezuela's realistic repertoire is narrow and shaped entirely by danger. The tactics that work and can be done relatively safely are **documentation from a distance, legitimate Indigenous organisation and the assertion of territorial rights and withheld consent, testimony carried outward through the church and international partners, and international and inter-American advocacy.** Open protest, confrontation, or any action that brings people into contact with armed actors or militarised zones carries extreme and often lethal risk, and the state's broader repression means even peaceful public dissent can bring detention. This guide therefore steers you firmly toward the documentary, organisational, and international channels, and away from anything that puts bodies in front of guns.

Whatever the mix, keep it collective, keep it anchored in Indigenous legitimacy and the Constitution's own guarantees, protect the most exposed above all, and never let anyone — a witness, a documenter, a leader — stand alone or unprotected. Guard against the despair and trauma that a crisis this grave and this ignored can bring, by sharing the load, caring for one another, drawing on the church and the community's own resilience, and holding to the knowledge that the record you build is reaching a world that is, slowly, beginning to see. Endurance, safety, and international connection are how Venezuela's defenders have survived and made their crisis known.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES

Legal action in Venezuela must be understood honestly: the domestic courts will not, in practice, deliver a remedy against state-backed and armed-group-driven mining, so domestic litigation is chiefly a way to build the record and exhaust remedies for the international stage — while the real legal power lies in the inter-American, UN, and market channels, and in the authoritative fact of the project's illegality under Venezuela's own law. This section explains the openings. It is not a substitute for a lawyer, and finding trustworthy legal accompaniment — ideally with an international human-rights organisation — is an early and vital task.

The Domestic Openings — Real Mainly as a Record

Constitutional and administrative actions. In principle, the violation of Articles 129 (impact study) and 120 (Indigenous consultation) could ground constitutional and administrative challenges to the Arco Minero and specific projects. In practice, the captured courts will not overturn the state's flagship extraction. File such actions, where safe and advised, primarily to establish that domestic remedies were sought and denied — a prerequisite and a powerful fact for the international stage.

The Environmental Penal Law. Environmental destruction is a crime under Venezuela's own law. A domestic complaint is unlikely to be prosecuted against protected actors, but it documents that a crime is being committed and creates a record.

The National Assembly's law. The 2018 declaration that all mining in the Arco Minero and protected areas is illegal is not enforced by the government, but it is an authoritative domestic legal instrument to cite everywhere.

The International Channels — Where the Power Is

For a Venezuelan community these are the substantive legal levers:

- **The Inter-American Commission on Human Rights (IACHR).** Although Venezuela withdrew from the Inter-American Court's contentious jurisdiction, it remains subject to the Commission's monitoring as an OAS member. The IACHR receives **petitions, requests for precautionary measures** to protect people at grave risk, and information, and has taken up the Arco Minero and the absence of Indigenous consultation. This is among the most substantive channels available.
- **The UN human-rights system.** The OHCHR presence, the special mechanisms (including on Indigenous peoples, the environment, and human-rights defenders), and the Fact-Finding Mission on Venezuela receive information and produce authoritative findings and pressure.
- **ILO Convention 169 mechanisms.** As a party, Venezuela's violation of the consultation obligation can be raised

through the ILO's supervisory bodies.

- **Market, sanctions, and due-diligence channels.** The regimes governing Venezuelan gold — sanctions, and the due-diligence obligations of refiners, buyers, and financiers — are a legal-and-commercial lever on the destruction's economic lifeline, reachable by documenting the gold's origin and route.

Standing, Exhaustion, and Safety

Three points. First, **exhaustion**: the international bodies generally expect domestic remedies to have been sought or shown to be unavailable, so a documented attempt (and its futility) strengthens the international case. Second, **standing and partnership**: Indigenous peoples through their authorities, affected individuals, and organisations can bring international petitions, and an experienced international human-rights organisation is often essential to do so effectively. Third — and paramount — **safety**: litigating or petitioning can expose people, so protective measures, secure handling, and international accompaniment must accompany every legal step, and no one should carry a dangerous filing alone.

What Legal Action Realistically Achieves

Be clear-eyed. Domestic litigation in Venezuela will rarely stop a project; its value is the record and the exhaustion of remedies. The international channels can deliver authoritative findings, precautionary measures that protect people, sustained scrutiny that raises the crime's cost, and market and diplomatic pressure on the gold — real achievements that have, in this crisis, been the meaningful ones. Combined with documentation, Indigenous organisation, and international advocacy, legal action on the inter-American and UN stage — built on the project's illegality under Venezuela's own Constitution — is the substantive legal path here. Treat the domestic courts as the record-builder and the international bodies and markets as where the law can still bite, and never pursue either without security for your people.

The Inter-American and ILO Routes in More Detail

Two international routes deserve particular attention. Before the **Inter-American Commission**, the most immediately useful tool is the **request for precautionary measures**, which asks the Commission to call on the State to protect people at grave and urgent risk; it can be sought relatively quickly, does not require the case to be fully litigated, and both protects named individuals and raises the profile and cost of the situation. A **petition** on the merits is slower but can produce authoritative findings on the State's violations of the rights to consultation, a healthy environment, territory, health, and life — findings that carry weight internationally even though Venezuela has withdrawn from the Court's contentious jurisdiction. Separately, because Venezuela is a party to **ILO Convention 169**, the failure to consult the affected Indigenous peoples can be raised through the **ILO's supervisory mechanisms**, adding a further authoritative body on record. In every instance, work with an experienced international human-rights organisation: the framing, the evidence standards, and the protection of those named all benefit decisively from expert accompaniment, and the filing itself can expose people, so security must accompany it.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades an Inter-American Commission lawyer, a UN investigator, an international journalist, a gold-market compliance officer, and a bishop in different ways. In Venezuela, where the audiences that matter are mostly international, learning to translate your evidence for each is what lets a community reach past a captured state to the bodies that can act.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, satellite imagery showing a mining pit spreading across Indigenous territory inside a protected area, with no environmental-impact study and no consultation ever conducted. That one fact becomes:

- **A constitutional-illegality argument:** the activity violates Articles 129 and 120 of Venezuela's own Constitution and the National Assembly's law — it is unlawful by the country's supreme law.
- **An Indigenous-rights argument:** the free, prior, and informed consultation and consent required by the Constitution and ILO 169 were never obtained — a binding violation the inter-American, UN, and ILO bodies enforce.
- **An inter-American argument:** the state has failed its duties to protect the environment, Indigenous territory, and the life and integrity of the affected people — grounds for a petition and precautionary measures before the IACHR.
- **A market argument:** gold produced on illegally-mined, unconsulted Indigenous land in a protected area cannot satisfy responsible-sourcing due diligence — a fact for refiners, buyers, and financiers.
- **A moral and media argument:** a sacred river and an Indigenous people are being poisoned for gold, in secret, in the

Amazon — a story the world is beginning to hear.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest documented facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The Inter-American Commission and UN bodies want the violation framed against the specific rights and standards they uphold — consultation and consent, a healthy environment, Indigenous territory, life and integrity — with dated, sourced proof and, for precautionary measures, a clear and documented risk to named people.

Markets, refiners, and sanctioning states want provable origin and illegality: that the gold comes from unlawfully mined, unconsulted, protected land, entangled with armed groups — the facts that trigger due-diligence and sanctions obligations.

International media and the global public want the human and planetary story made vivid and true: the poisoned river, the mercury, the Indigenous people unconsulted, the Amazon devastation hidden from view. Lead with the people and the place; supply the proof; keep it accurate.

The church and Indigenous networks want testimony and solidarity grounded in the community's own account and dignity.

The Master Frame: "An Illegal Crime Against the Constitution, the Amazon, and Its Peoples"

Across every audience, the strongest frame in Venezuela is the same, and it is factually true: this is not a lawful development a community happens to oppose — it is an activity carried out in violation of Venezuela's own Constitution, without the impact study and the Indigenous consultation the supreme law demands, rejected by the National Assembly, devastating the Amazon and poisoning its peoples, enforced by armed groups. Framing the fight this way is accurate; it is legally powerful, engaging the inter-American, UN, ILO, and market channels at once; it is protective, because it casts your community as rights-holders and the mining as the crime; and it is the frame the international attention that has begun to reach this crisis responds to. In a country where the state will not enforce its own law, insisting — with evidence, before the world — that the law has been broken is both your strongest argument and part of your shield.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and international visibility, in Venezuela, are not a supporting tactic — they are close to the whole strategy, because a crime this hidden loses much of its impunity once the world can see it, and because visibility is one of the few protections a defender has. But media must be used with acute care for safety, because exposure can also endanger, and because the state's repression reaches those who speak inside the country. Use it deliberately, mostly through international channels, and always in service of both the goal and the protection of your people.

What Coverage Achieves

International coverage ends the invisibility the Arco Minero has depended on; it raises the political, reputational, and diplomatic cost to the state and to the buyers of the gold; it reaches and reinforces the inter-American and UN bodies; it supports requests for protection; and it brings the global concern for the Amazon to bear on a crisis that, in the words of those who study it, has drawn far too little attention. The documentation model that made the Arco Minero visible worked precisely by turning evidence into international coverage.

Build the Story Around People, Place, Proof — and Illegality

The most powerful Venezuelan stories join a human and planetary face to a documented fact and the frame of illegality: an Indigenous people poisoned by mercury on land opened to mining without their consent and against the Constitution; a sacred river and a forest torn up for gold; satellite images of devastation that was meant to stay hidden. Lead with the people and the place; supply the proof and the illegality; keep it accurate. Prepare clear, repeatable messages and, crucially, decide with the people themselves and with experienced allies who — if anyone — is named and who is protected by anonymity.

Reach the Channels That Matter — Mostly International

International media and documentation organisations are the primary channel: a well-documented Amazon-mining and Indigenous-rights story resonates globally and brings the scrutiny the Venezuelan state cannot deflect. **International human-rights and environmental networks** amplify, protect, and connect. **The church's international voice** carries moral weight. **Independent and exile Venezuelan media** can reach the wider public, with care for the risks. **Domestic and social channels** must be used with great caution given surveillance and repression, and never in a way that exposes those on the ground. In every case, weight the effort toward the international, where the impact is greatest and the danger to your people least.

Discipline and Safety Above All

Be accurate always; a single exaggeration handed to a state that calls its critics spies and traitors can discredit a campaign and endanger it. Stay grounded in evidence, illegality, and rights. Anticipate the state's counter-narrative — that critics are foreign agents or enemies of the nation — and pre-empt it by grounding everything in Venezuela's own Constitution and law and in the community's own testimony. Above all, protect the people: weigh with great care whether and how anyone inside the country is identified, understanding that for those on the ground exposure is often danger, while it is the international partners and the evidence itself that can safely carry the public message. In Venezuela, the media strategy that works is the one that makes the crime visible to the world through international channels and evidence — because that visibility is, at once, the pressure on the powerful and a shield for the people who would otherwise face the guns unseen.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you reach the bodies that can act, create a record, and summon protection. In Venezuela, most of the letters that matter go outward — to the international, inter-American, and market channels — and every one does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, stored securely and shared with trusted allies abroad. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, grounded in evidence and in Venezuela's own law, and — where people are at risk — precise about the danger. Take advice before sending anything that names individuals inside the country.

8A. Request for Inter-American Precautionary Measures

To: Inter-American Commission on Human Rights (IACHR) **Subject:** Request for precautionary measures — [community/people], Bolívar/Amazonas, Venezuela

We request precautionary measures for [named persons/community/Indigenous people], who face serious and urgent risk of irreparable harm in connection with mining on their territory in [location]. The risk is shown by [documented threats, violence, mercury contamination, militarisation — attached]. The activity proceeds without the environmental-impact study (Constitution Art. 129) or the free, prior, and informed consultation (Art. 120) Venezuela's own law requires. The State has failed to protect the beneficiaries and is implicated in the harm. We ask the Commission to request that Venezuela adopt measures to protect their life, integrity, and territory, in consultation with them, and report on the measures taken.

8B. Petition to the Inter-American Commission

To: IACHR — Petitions **Subject:** Petition — violation of the rights of [Indigenous people/community], Venezuela

On behalf of [petitioners], we submit that the State of Venezuela has violated the rights to consultation and consent, to a healthy environment, to property and territory, to health, and to life and integrity of [people], through the [Arco Minero/named project], carried out without the impact study and consultation required by the Constitution and ILO Convention 169 and declared illegal by the National Assembly. Domestic remedies are unavailable or ineffective, as shown by [attached]. We request admissibility, a finding of violations, and recommendations for remedy and protection.

8C. Submission to UN Human-Rights Mechanisms

To: the UN Special Rapporteurs (Indigenous peoples / environment / human-rights defenders) and OHCHR **Subject:** Information — mining harm and lack of consultation, [location], Venezuela

We submit information on [situation]: mining on the territory of [people] without consultation or consent, causing

[deforestation, mercury contamination, health harm, violence — documented and attached], in violation of Venezuela's Constitution and international obligations. We request the mandates' attention, communication with the State, and, where appropriate, public expression of concern.

8D. Partnership Request to an International Documentation Organisation

To: [international documentation / human-rights / environmental organisation] **Subject:** Request for documentation support — mining harm, [location], Venezuela

We are [community / Indigenous organisation / allies] documenting mining harm at [location]. We seek your support with [satellite monitoring, secure documentation, legal framing, international advocacy], and safe channels to carry the evidence to the IACHR, the UN, and responsible-sourcing bodies. Attached is our documented account. Given the danger, we ask for secure communication and guidance on protecting those on the ground.

8E. Appeal to the Church and Humanitarian Networks

To: [diocese / church / humanitarian network] **Subject:** Accompaniment and witness — [community], mining south

We write from [community], facing mining harm and threats at [location]. We ask for the Church's accompaniment, witness, protection, and help carrying our testimony safely to those who can act. We attach a careful account, and ask for guidance on protecting the most exposed among us.

8F. Domestic Constitutional / Administrative Action (Record-Building)

To: the competent court / the Public Prosecutor, as advised by counsel **Subject:** Action regarding [project/decreed] — violation of Articles 129 and 120

As [affected persons / Indigenous authority], we bring this action regarding [the activity at location], carried out without the environmental-impact study (Art. 129) and the Indigenous consultation (Art. 120) the Constitution requires, and within [a protected area / the southern megareserve]. We request [suspension / annulment / investigation] and we place on record the constitutional and legal violations, reserving all international remedies.

8G. Environmental-Crime Complaint

To: the environmental prosecutor / competent authority **Subject:** Report of environmental crime — [location]

We report environmental destruction constituting a crime under the Environmental Penal Law at [location]: [deforestation, mercury contamination, river destruction — documented]. We request investigation and action, and we place the facts and their gravity on the record.

8H. Responsible-Sourcing / Due-Diligence Alert

To: [refiner / buyer / financier / sanctions authority], as advised **Subject:** Origin alert — gold from illegally-mined, unconsulted Indigenous land, Venezuela

We provide information that gold [reaching / associated with] your supply chain originates in the Venezuelan Arco Minero, mined unlawfully on Indigenous territory without consultation, in a protected area, and entangled with armed groups — facts material to your responsible-sourcing due diligence and to applicable sanctions. We attach our documented account and ask what steps you will take.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline, stored securely. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in evidence and in Venezuela's own law; attach your documentation; and, where people are at risk, be precise and urgent about the danger. Route them, wherever possible, through or with an experienced international partner who can strengthen the framing and protect those on the ground. The reply — or the silence — becomes part of your record, and in Venezuela that record, carried outward, is both the engine of your case and part of the shield around your people.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE

RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes the miners or the armed men have already arrived, or the threats have begun, and you cannot read this whole guide first. This is the compressed version. Do these things, in this order — and put safety first, always.

1. Protect people before anything else. Assess the danger honestly. If armed actors are present, the first priority is the safety of your people — distance, discretion, and, if necessary, relocation. Never confront the guns. No documentation or campaign is worth a life.

2. Reach a trusted external ally immediately. Contact — securely — an international documentation or human-rights organisation, a trusted Indigenous organisation, or the church. In Venezuela the leverage and much of the protection are external, so this connection is the most important early move, and it should not wait.

3. Document from a safe distance. Begin a dated record: satellite or remote imagery of the harm, the location and the Indigenous territory affected, any evidence of mercury, health harm, or violence gathered without exposure. Store it securely and share copies with allies abroad.

4. Establish the illegality. Note the facts that make it unlawful under Venezuela's own law: no environmental-impact study (Art. 129), no Indigenous consultation (Art. 120), location in a protected area or the southern megareserve, the National Assembly's declaration of illegality. This is your strongest instrument abroad.

5. Anchor in Indigenous authority. Work through the affected people's own councils and organisations — the legitimate decision-makers, the front-line witnesses, and the foundation of both the legal case and the resistance. Centre their withheld consent.

6. Prepare a protection request. Where anyone is threatened, prepare — with your external ally — a request for Inter-American precautionary measures and a submission to the UN mechanisms, documenting the risk to named people.

7. Carry it outward, not into confrontation. Get the documented case to the international, inter-American, and — where relevant — market and church channels. The fight is won by making the crime visible and costly to the world, not by meeting force on the ground.

Do these seven things and you will have protected your people, connected to the allies who can act, begun a secure record, established the illegality, anchored in Indigenous legitimacy, prepared protection, and pointed the case outward to where it can bite. Then come back and read the rest — and read the organising and tilted-system sections with the greatest care.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Venezuela's system is not merely tilted; on the mining south it has, as a protector of the environment and of rights, largely collapsed. You must understand this precisely — so you neither waste your strength on institutions that will not act nor, far worse, expose your people to the armed reality on the ground.

Where the Tilt — and the Collapse — Shows

The executive created the Arco Minero by decree, over the Constitution's requirements and the National Assembly's rejection. The environmental and mining ministries administer extraction rather than restraining it. The courts and prosecutors will not act against the state's flagship source of hard currency. The zone is militarised, and the armed forces are entangled in the mining economy; on the ground, *sindicatos* and Colombian guerrilla groups control mines under military protection or complicity, in what observers call lawlessness. Civil society and the press face broad repression, journalists and observers who probe the mining have been detained, and Venezuela has withdrawn from the Inter-American Court's contentious jurisdiction. This is not a system with a referee to persuade; it is one in which the state and armed actors are the beneficiaries, and the ordinary levers of a functioning country — courts, regulators, protest — are absent or lethal.

What Still Works — And It Is Real, and Mostly External

The crucial thing to hold onto is that even amid this collapse, real levers remain — almost all of them outside the Venezuelan state.

The illegality is a permanent instrument. Because the Arco Minero was created without the constitutionally-required

impact study and Indigenous consultation, and was rejected by the National Assembly, it is unlawful under Venezuela's own supreme law. That fact, unenforceable at home, is a powerful and durable instrument before the IACHR, the UN, the ILO, and the markets.

International documentation has changed what the world can see. Satellite monitoring, field networks, and international advocacy have turned a hidden devastation into a documented global crime — the single most effective thing that has been done here.

The inter-American and UN bodies still reach. The IACHR still monitors Venezuela and can grant precautionary measures and findings; the UN mechanisms and Fact-Finding Mission document and pressure. These operate where the domestic courts will not.

Indigenous organisation and the church endure. The affected peoples' own authorities and the church remain legitimate, functioning, and relatively protected voices and witnesses.

The gold's route to market is a pressure point. Sanctions and responsible-sourcing due diligence reach the destruction's economic lifeline.

The Honest Frame — and the Warning

So the honest frame for Venezuela is sober, and it carries the gravest safety warning in this guide. Stopping the Arco Minero from within Venezuela, by domestic legal or political means, is not a realistic near-term goal, and confronting the armed actors who enforce it on the ground is lethal. But making the crime visible and undeniable, establishing its illegality before the world, winning authoritative findings and precautionary measures from the inter-American and UN bodies, protecting people, anchoring Indigenous territorial defence and withheld consent, and constraining the gold's route to market are all real, achievable, and — in this crisis — the things that have actually been done. Diagnose the collapse honestly, keep your people away from the guns, build the documented case, and carry it to the international arena where Venezuela's own institutions will not go. That is the method that fits this reality — and it is the one most likely to protect both the forest and the people who would defend it.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Venezuela's mining south, corruption is not a hidden distortion of the system; it is, in large part, the system. Recognising this matters, because it tells you where the harm's true drivers lie, why domestic remedies are futile, and where — carefully — the crime can still be reached.

Signs of Capture — and of Something Beyond It

Watch for the patterns the reporting on the Arco Minero describes. A mega-project created by decree over the Constitution and against the National Assembly's vote. Environmental and consultation requirements simply skipped. A militarised zone where the armed forces are entangled in the mining economy. Mines run by *sindicatos* and Colombian guerrilla groups under military protection. Gold moving through opaque channels to evade sanctions and enrich state and armed networks. Journalists and observers detained for asking questions a state enterprise's public status should make answerable. This is capture that has passed into something closer to a criminalised economy, in which the state, the military, and armed groups profit together from an activity that is illegal under the country's own law.

Why This Changes Your Strategy — and Where the Danger Lies

Where the drivers of harm are armed and state-protected, persuading a domestic institution is futile and confronting the actors is lethal. So the strategy shifts entirely to the external and evidentiary, pursued with the utmost care for safety:

- **Document the illegality and the harm, not the individuals.** Focus on the provable facts — the missing impact study, the missing consultation, the deforestation and mercury, the protected-area and territorial violations — rather than on naming powerful or armed people, which is both hard to prove and acutely dangerous.
- **Follow the gold to the markets.** The most reachable lever against a criminalised gold economy is the responsible-sourcing and sanctions machinery abroad: documented illegal origin is material to refiners, buyers, financiers, and sanctioning states.
- **Carry the corruption case to the international bodies.** The IACHR, the UN mechanisms, and international investigative and documentation organisations can address state complicity and the collapse of protection in ways no

domestic body will.

- **Rely on the church and Indigenous organisations** as protected witnesses to what is happening.

Document It Carefully, Collectively, and Safely

If you are documenting a criminalised, armed, state-protected mining economy, do so with rigour, restraint, and the greatest care for safety — which here can mean life or death. Distinguish always between what you can prove and what you suspect; allege only what your evidence supports; and be especially careful never to name or approach powerful or armed individuals, focusing instead on the hard, verifiable facts of illegality and harm. Gather from a safe distance, prefer remote and satellite evidence, protect every witness's identity, store everything securely and with allies abroad, and route the case outward through experienced international partners. In Venezuela, documented illegality and harm — carried to the inter-American and UN bodies and to the gold markets — is the only way this criminalised economy is ever constrained, and doing the work safely, collectively, and from a distance the armed actors cannot close is essential to surviving it.

Following the Gold to the Markets

The most reachable pressure point on Venezuela's criminalised mining economy lies where the gold leaves the country. Under sanctions, and under the responsible-sourcing due-diligence standards that bind refiners, banks, and buyers, gold of illegal or conflict-linked origin is supposed to be excluded from legitimate supply chains — and gold from the Arco Minero, mined unlawfully on unconsulted Indigenous land, in protected areas, and entangled with armed groups, is precisely such gold. Documenting the origin and, where possible, the route and the intermediaries turns your evidence into information that is material to those actors' legal and reputational obligations and to the sanctioning authorities. This is a channel a community cannot work alone, but one that international documentation and investigative organisations have used to constrain the destruction's economic lifeline. It also underscores why the documentary, origin-focused approach — rather than any confrontation on the ground — is both the safest and the most consequential path: it attacks the money without ever facing the guns.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps in this guide are not a menu to pick from; they are strands to weave together over time — safely, and with the international dimension and the protection of people woven through everything. This section shows how they combine, and roughly when each comes into play.

How the Strands Reinforce Each Other

The power of a Venezuelan campaign comes from combining its strands while keeping people safe and pointing the whole effort outward. **Safety and Indigenous organisation** are the foundation. **Documentation** — especially remote and satellite — feeds everything: the illegality case, the inter-American and UN petitions, the media, the market alerts, the protection requests. **The illegality under Venezuela's own law** is the thread that runs through every argument. **The international, inter-American, and UN channels** turn the record into scrutiny, findings, and protection. **Market and sanctions pressure** reaches the gold. **The church and international solidarity** protect and amplify. Each strand strengthens the others: documented harm becomes an illegality case, becomes an IACHR petition and a UN submission, becomes international coverage, becomes market pressure, becomes cost to those who profit — while Indigenous organisation and the church hold and protect the people through it. No single strand stops this crime; woven together and carried outward, they have made it visible and begun to make it costly.

A Rough Timeline

Early (first days and weeks). Protect people first; assess the armed danger honestly. Connect securely with an international ally, a trusted Indigenous organisation, and the church. Begin safe, remote documentation and establish the illegality. Anchor in Indigenous authority and withheld consent. Where anyone is threatened, prepare a protection request. This early phase — above all the establishment of safety and external connection — can be the difference between life and death.

Building (weeks to months). Deepen the documentation, including the secure record of threats. With your external partners, prepare and file the inter-American petition and precautionary-measure request and the UN submissions, exhaust or document the futility of domestic remedies, and build the international media presence and the market/due-diligence alerts. Pace yourself; this runs for months, and the care of your people through it is part of the work.

Sustained (months to years). Keep the documentation, the international engagement, the media, and the Indigenous and church anchors alive together, adapting as the situation and the danger shift. Sustain the people through a crisis that is grave, dangerous, and too long ignored, by sharing the load, caring for one another, and holding to the knowledge that the record is reaching a world beginning to see. Endurance, safety, and international connection are how this crisis has been made known.

Throughout. Reassess honestly and continually — the situation, the danger, and whether the goal still fits. If a lever works, press it; if the danger to people rises beyond what any outcome can justify, protect them first — secure them, preserve the documentation with allies abroad, relocate if necessary — and adapt. Keep the record current, secure, and shared outward. And keep the safety of your people the first consideration at every step: in Venezuela there is no outcome worth a life, and the documentary, Indigenous-anchored, international path is the one that both protects people and reaches the crime.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Honest Bottom Line

Venezuela presents one of the gravest and most dangerous situations in this entire guide, and it has not been softened here. The institutions that should protect the environment and Indigenous peoples have collapsed or been captured; a mega-mining zone larger than many countries was opened over the Constitution's own requirements and against the National Assembly's vote; the zone is militarised and much of it controlled by armed groups; and those who document or resist face detention, violence, and worse. Stopping this from within Venezuela, by domestic means, is not a realistic near-term goal, and confronting the armed actors on the ground is lethal.

And yet there are real, hard truths on the other side. The Arco Minero is **illegal under Venezuela's own supreme law** — no impact study, no Indigenous consultation, rejected by the National Assembly — and that illegality is a durable instrument before the world. Rigorous **documentation, above all satellite and remote monitoring, has turned a hidden devastation into a documented global crime.** The **Inter-American Commission and the United Nations still reach** where the courts will not, taking up the absence of consultation and the toll on Indigenous peoples. **Indigenous organisations and the church endure** as legitimate, protected voices. And the **gold's route to world markets** is a genuine pressure point. These are not nothing; in this crisis, they are the things that have actually been achieved, and they can be built upon.

On a formal, nameable actor, reachable through documentation and the international channels, a community and its allies have a real chance of exposing the crime, establishing its illegality, winning inter-American or UN scrutiny and protection, and raising its cost. Where the harm is armed-group-driven and militarised, the realistic and responsible aims are documentation from safety, protection of people, and feeding the record outward — and protection itself is the first victory. What is never wise in Venezuela is to face the guns; the method that fits this reality is documentary, Indigenous-anchored, and international.

What Distinguishes the Efforts That Achieve Something

The efforts that achieve something in Venezuela share a pattern. They put the safety of people first and never confront the armed actors. They document rigorously and safely, especially from a distance. They anchor in Indigenous authority and withheld consent, and lean on the church. They build everything on the project's illegality under Venezuela's own Constitution and law. And they carry the case outward — to the IACHR, the UN, the international media, and the gold markets — because that is where, in a collapsed system, the crime can still be reached. The efforts that come to grief do the opposite: they confront the guns, they rely on captured domestic institutions, they expose their people, or they let a crisis this grave and this ignored break their endurance before the world is made to see.

A Closing Word

If you are reading this because mining threatens your forest, your river, your territory, or your people, understand that in Venezuela the situation is grave and the danger is real — but understand equally that you are not without recourse, and that the very illegality and hidden cruelty of what is being done are, carried to the world, its greatest vulnerabilities. The method is clear: protect your people first and never face the guns; document safely; anchor in Indigenous rights and the Constitution's own words; and carry the case to the international bodies and markets that can act where Venezuela's institutions will not. It does not promise a quick end to a crime this entrenched, and it asks you to accept real limits and real danger. But it is the method by which the Arco Minero was made visible to the world, by which Indigenous peoples' unconsulted lands and poisoned rivers have been placed before the inter-American and United Nations bodies, and by

which the pressure on this crisis, though still far too small, has begun to grow. Judge your effort by those outcomes, keep your people safe and never alone, and hold to the knowledge that a crime made visible is a crime that has begun, at last, to be resisted.